



LET US LAY THE CORNERSTONE OF AMERICAN FREEDOM WITHOUT FEAR. TO HESITATE IS TO PERISH

BOLÍVAR ESTABLISHES GRAN COLOMBIA (1819)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Latin American independence

BEFORE

1807–1808 Napoleonic invasion of Iberia leads to governmental crisis in the Iberian colonies of South America.

1819 Spain is expelled from its former province of New Granada, and the Republic of Colombia is declared.

AFTER

1822 Portugal assents to Brazil becoming a constitutional monarchy under Pedro I.

1824 The Spanish capitulate in Peru, and their New World empire ends.

1830 Break up of the Republic of Colombia. Ecuador, Colombia, and Venezuela emerge as independent states.

The establishment in 1819 of the Republic of Colombia, or Gran Colombia as it came to be known, by Simón Bolívar, the self-styled *Libertador*, marked a pivotal moment in the emergence of an independent Latin America.

By 1825, the continent had successfully ended almost 300 years of Spanish and Portuguese rule. In Brazil, which won its independence in 1822, the process was relatively easy and also largely bloodless. Elsewhere, it was complex, long, drawn out,

and violent. It was a reflection of societies comprising a teeming range of classes and races—ruling Europeans, native peoples, black people, and those of mixed race—that were never likely to produce coherent political wholes. Plagued by bitter disputes, the short-lived republic of Gran Colombia would break up in 1830.

Brazilian independence

Though partly influenced by the liberal doctrines of the American and French revolutions, the drive to independence in South America was seldom the product of a desire for social justice or representative government. Aside from two abortive Mexican revolutions in 1810 and 1813, it was a struggle for supremacy between ruling elites, none of which had much interest in the kind of social change—society recast on liberal principles—that underpinned the French Revolution. That said, this drive was also significantly affected by the Napoleonic Wars. Napoleon's invasion of Portugal in 1807 forced the Portuguese king, João VI, and his court to flee to safety in its Brazilian colony. João remained there even after the fall of Napoleon in 1815, returning to Portugal only in 1821. However, his son and heir, Pedro, stayed in Brazil.

As in Spain's Latin American colonies, Brazil was dominated by a land-owning elite, a great many of whom, over many generations, had been born in South America. They came to resent the fact that ultimate authority was exercised by a distant monarchy, and saw no reason why they should submit to it.